

eg update

送信者: Ian Bremmer 受信日時: 2026-07-13 20:47

【メール原文】

dear hondo-san,

a solid nato summit. no iran ceasefire, no war either. and ai governance.

nato summit

the second successful western alliance confab in a month. first, macron's g7 summit in evian, and now, erdogan's nato summit in ankara.

turkish president recep tayyip erdogan is one of president trump's warmest bilateral relationships, and trump made it clear that he was attending the nato summit in large part because he liked the man who was hosting. trump announced an end to the 2020 caatsa sanctions (put in place because turkey was buying s-400 missile defense systems from russia), and also that he wanted to sell f35 jet fighters to turkey (up to congress and unlikely to pass...but still notable given the strident opposition to turkey that israeli pm benjamin netanyahu had voiced hours before). indeed, trump compared turkey favorably to israel, long a closer ally to the americans.

trump's main takeaway was praise for unity among the nato allies, saying the summit was filled with "tremendous love." not without rough patches to be sure, with the american president also criticizing most of the european leaders for their unwillingness to come to america's aid in the war in iran. that included direct callouts of germany, italy, the united kingdom and france, for not being there when the united states potentially (though not really) needed them. with trump reserving particular animosity for spain, saying (for about 24 hours, until he reversed himself) the united states would stop trading with them. president trump brought up greenland again as territory the americans should have control over given denmark's lack of spending and capacity to defend against chinese naval incursions in the area. still, there wasn't any "or else" in trump's hostility—either on nato withdrawal, trade hostilities, or territorial expansion.

in part that's because trump is more aligned with nato than he used to be: europe is spending significantly more (and much of the nato summit was the europeans presenting to the united states just how much more they're spending, with a number of additional/incremental new defense announcements), in part due to trump's own push, so there's less of an agenda item there. also importantly, the united states is no longer spending taxpayer dollars on ukraine...but the ukrainians are nonetheless now performing significantly better in the war, all the while russian president vladimir putin refuses to accept trump's entreaties for a ceasefire. ukrainian president volodymyr zelensky ended up having his best meeting with president trump since the war started, with trump offering to allow ukraine licenses so they can produce patriot interceptors for themselves (which will take years to have meaningful war impact, but reflects a decidedly different orientation toward ukraine by the american president). and publicly supporting ukraine's targeting of russian energy facilities deep inside russia—an escalation that, as he described it, "could help end the war."

in short, trump has now shifted from having cut off support for ukraine, suspending intelligence and military engagement after abruptly ending a zelensky white house visit last spring, to a more de facto hawkish pro-ukraine military position than president biden was willing to offer. all reflecting a dramatic

change in how trump perceives the war, and his frustration in having received nothing in return for the diplomatic effort expended on putin over the first year of this administration. for the european allies, it's a considerably less uncomfortable position to be in.

add nato/russia to china/trade and iran/middle east on the list of global issues where president trump's initial policies have faced constraints and led to climbdown. as i wrote last week, we're now well past the global tipping point on peak trump disruption.

iran

the nato summit blowup wasn't about nato...but the breaking of the ceasefire and sudden escalation in fighting between the americans and iranians (which, notably, president trump didn't bring up during the dinner the night before at the nato summit). iran last week and this past weekend targeted a number of ships sailing through the strait, including a saudi oil and qatari lng tanker, leading the us president to retaliate with the most significant steps since ending the blockade: revoking sanctions waivers against iran, authorizing two nights of military strikes against a large number of iranian targets (including two railway bridges, damaged but not collapsed—so a clear "warning strike" from the americans), and declaring the us-iran ceasefire and preliminary deal "over." we've also seen targeted strikes by iran against gulf targets and strikes back from kuwait and bahrain, supported by the united arab emirates and in coordination with centcom.

all unwelcome developments for the nato allies, to be sure. but still not so different from where we were a month ago. president trump wants the war over and isn't prepared to engage in large-scale escalation (and certainly doesn't want ground strikes to "take the oil" or precipitate a regime change, given the expected costs). while iran's problem is that they're concerned about losing their leverage over hormuz and want to ensure that they get paid. and just as the united states has not withdrawn most of their military assets from the region (a quip circulating among the us brass is that the united states can't possibly fight two ceasefires at a time), so too has iran maintained its willingness to engage in attacks.

the last few weeks have shown transit through the strait of hormuz substantially recovering, to about 20-25 daily transits (about 25% of pre-war levels). but only about 25% of that has gone through the iranian northern passage in the strait, with the rest either taking the southern route (through oman), the central waterway (easier to navigate but still in the process of de-mining), or transiting dark without automatic identification system (ais) transponders operative. add to that lower oil prices (pushed further downward by a price war between the saudis and emiratis) and higher overall supply, all of which limits iran's leverage over the strait.

conclusion: the gulf states are gaining an upper hand in the de facto outcome of strait transit, while none of the discussed unfreezing of iranian assets (by qatar or the uae) has to date taken place. the gulf states are accordingly pushing iran to accept a compromise with limited economic upside; iran wants to ensure it can drive a more favorable outcome—not necessarily tolls per ship, but some sort of ongoing influence and payment scheme for the strait. president trump is still prepared to negotiate, with the americans expecting to settle on a "turkey/dardanelles" like model (no per-ship toll, but a country fund that other countries will contribute to). but still, having also calculated (correctly, in my view) that the trump administration doesn't want to return to a full war footing, iran sees little downside from lashing out militarily to improve their position.

to be sure, there's danger that iranian overconfidence and american frustration lead to another complete disruption of the strait. if the united states reimposes a blockade of iranian ports, that would lead to a more significant military escalation from iran, both against major gulf targets and us military

targets, and another shutdown of the strait of hormuz (and potentially the red sea as well)...which could in turn tip the americans into a broader military response, however reluctant president trump has been to take that decision. and indeed, trump has once again threatened to "take the oil" in kharg island, blow up critical iranian infrastructure, and take out the iranian leadership as tensions continue to mount. but it's much more likely that the american president moves unilaterally in the other direction, "doing it without a deal" as he suggested—where trump ends negotiations with the iranians but also pulls most military capacity out of the region, making the strait a gulf problem (that they negotiate) and only prepared to bomb again if and when iran starts redeveloping their nuclear capabilities.

one continued wildcard: israeli prime minister benjamin netanyahu, facing elections in october and—looking at present polling—more likely than not to lose. the closer we get to that outcome, the more likely the israelis are to precipitate military escalation against hezbollah (iran's principal proxy in the region) and/or iran directly, themselves. hence israel's public release of intelligence on an iranian plot to assassinate president trump (quickly disregarded by the american president as nothing new). it's a risky strategy, but for the israeli prime minister the prospect of incarceration following an electoral loss is worse. so the timing, notably just before us midterm elections, is consequential...

ai governance

one of my favorite conversations among global leaders involves aliens. us president ronald reagan was meeting soviet general secretary mikhael gorbachev in geneva at their first summit in 1985. reagan suddenly asked "what would you do if aliens suddenly attacked the united states, you'd come to our defense, wouldn't you?" gorbachev said of course he would. reagan said he would too. that unexpected bit of common humanity led to a breakthrough between the two leaders in a cold war against what reagan had long considered the "evil empire."

i've been thinking about a different alien metaphor recently. if aliens looked down at our planet and saw the state of technological development, they'd get excited. of all the times to happen upon a planet, they had picked just the moment—literally an eyeblink cosmologically—when human life has discovered technology to reinvent themselves and their role on the planet. to witness this transformation, after billions of years of life evolving uneventfully on a planet, and then suddenly on the precipice of remaking it and themselves through artificial intelligence, and the creation of even more capable entities, and so on, and so on. that's the turning point, it's by any measure an extraordinary time.

but if those same aliens then looked at the governance structure in the world—despite reagan and gorbachev finding their common humanity from their imagined visit—their perspective would change. if they considered the more than 200 designations of "sovereign" governments with varied political systems, at best limited trust, and frequently overt hostility toward each other. the reality that there exists essentially zero global governance, despite the fact that humans are now introducing new technologies with unprecedented global impact both for human development, human destruction, and implications for the world in both cases. the aliens would come to the conclusion that the present state of affairs isn't sustainable.

i never held that view about nuclear weapons, despite the massive damage they could do. after all, during the cold war only two countries possessed world destroying numbers and ultimately, even without mutual trust, the leaders of both retained a healthy fear of what the weapons could do (and some useful historical experience and memory). i haven't had that view of climate change, which is much slower moving...though also massively impactful (especially with the mass extinction of species we've already experienced as a consequence), but with humans belatedly but assuredly developing the

post-carbon energy technologies and investing in the scale to eventually address the problem.

artificial intelligence is another matter. it's too powerful, too fast moving (with new frontier releases now coming roughly every 10 days(!), as opposed to 40 back in 2023), and driven by humans who mostly don't understand the implications of what they're developing...but feel like they have to keep going as fast as possible nonetheless. and we don't have the friction of creating nuclear material when it comes to making more powerful ai, we're just running data centers. hearing ai leaders talk about the future is sobering on this count. whether supported by accelerationism (progress for the sake of progress, irrespective of implications for human beings), or out of learned helplessness: "yes, we might be about to destroy the planet, but there's no alternative because otherwise our competitors are going to do it, and that's even more dangerous." both justifications feel like insanity when you take a moment to think about it. but that's where we are.

when something is unsustainable it doesn't last, and in this case it means a far more significant regulatory environment is coming. likely after crisis as opposed to preemptively. but still, it's where we are heading, and soon.

a few thoughts on what that's likely to mean. first, the present government orientation toward pre-release testing isn't a meaningful fix, at least by itself. guardrails that companies develop are useful and important to coordinate with government oversight, but it's not going to stop the problem; the presumption should be that everything that comes out in a pre-release ai model is going to come out publicly and more and more quickly.

an essential next step will be governments creating expert-led agencies paired with know your customer/content/cloud and effective controls over what ai models and ai agents, interacting with humans and with each other, are up to. so that when dangerous activities occur (and the financial activities/tokens that pay for them), they can be identified, tracked, and shut down.

i'm reasonably optimistic about where this is heading on cyber concerns. the vulnerabilities identified with ai will lead to stronger systems—and there are market incentives (including and especially on behalf of the ai providers) to step up. the risks are greater, especially for older, smaller, systems in non-strategic sectors (among corporate and government actors alike), but none of this strikes me as catastrophic.

biosecurity is a different story. here, ai-supported genetic engineering is likely to create a step-change in the dangerousness of bioweapons. covid, ebola and other serious pathogens aren't very effective at killing lots of people—they're either too lethal to spread (ebola) or too spreadable to kill (covid). but with ai, you can engineer a bioweapon for maximum impact. the pieces for that are likely to be in place in short order: get agents to build things, use humans for discrete pieces, robots, cloud labs, and the like. the regulatory environment isn't made for this problem: right now it's intended to screen for certain types of known dangerous agents; instead, a system has to be put in place to screen for bioagents that are unknown.

on all of this, alignment on safety is becoming the essential issue. it requires the chinese being in the same room as the rest of us, as otherwise there's no ability to have systemic responses. it limits european and other "middle power" conversations on digital sovereignty, because there's ultimately no choice but to work with (and regulate) the most powerful models, irrespective of understandable concerns of a "kill switch" in the united states government to suddenly shut down access for national (but not necessarily international) security purposes. it also recognizes that mass surveillance in some levels is not only possible and cheap for governments, but also increasingly likely—for democracies and

authoritarian regimes—until and unless a more secure regulatory environment is put into place.

the bigger, more existential question is as the tools for effective cooperation, governance, and destruction are in the hands of multiples across humanity, is the human impulse for cooperation or competition ultimately stronger. because irrespective of how much algorithmic programming eventually nudges human beings, it's the humans who are doing the programming...and who will maintain control unless and until it's too late. that's a deeper, more philosophical conversation. some students of human history believe cooperation is a biological tendency, some the outcome of shared place and society—and understanding that/getting it right will surely play a role in whether or not we chaotic humans at our tipping point will prove capable of navigating our way through. or not.

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worth a mention of china's recent submarine-launched ballistic missile launch, the first ever in international waters...and just a few hours after australia signed its "ocean of peace" defense pact with fiji making the two nations formal treaty allies. it signaled clear intent to other island nations not to sign onto a pact with australia (the missile landed in an area near fiji/solomons/vanuatu/papua new guinea). risk averse, the chinese...but also much more comfortable displaying strength in their backyard. a worthwhile datapoint.

and the sudden passing of us senator lindsey graham (r-sc), one of the most internationally well-known (and, back in john mccain's day, one of the more well-respected) contemporary political figures in washington. very much an on-again, off-again, on-again vocal supporter of president trump; i found lindsey whip-smart and funny but also personally tortured and temperamental. behind the scenes, he remained a voice of restraint on a number of trump's more unilateralist foreign policies (russia/ukraine, afghanistan, and foreign aid), but he was also prepared to go to the mat and beyond when the president wanted him to. lindsey's direct meetings with european leaders telling them they had to give greenland to trump were some of the most self-defeating i've ever seen from an american politician. i'm sorry he never found peace.

i'm in new york this week, hope all well.

yours,
ian

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